Autobiography stated, in a way that was to become massively influential for Indians, a new possibility. It made clear to his compatriots that they ought not to limit themselves to a simple, monolithic choice – between, on the one hand, accepting the world inherited from their predecessors, a world of traditional religion and caste practice, or, on the other hand, embracing the modern world, dressing, speaking, eating and thinking like Englishmen. Neither inheritance nor emulation were necessary; rather, the task for Indians was to chose their selves, to construct a life of their own.

The method Gandhi devised in order to fashion such a life and self was that of 'experiment'. Experiment is the operative mode of *An Autobiography*, the narrative cause and impulse. In his quest for an ethical life, we find Gandhi conducting experiments in dancing and in householding, in education, washing, and laundry, in healing and medicine, in hygiene, politics, and dietetics, in fasting, and in earth and water treatment, in friendship, in communal living, and, of course, in truth. 'I wore out my body experimenting', Gandhi confessed of his strenuous devotion to the task, and still he kept at it, insisting that 'any number of experiments is too small'.

Through experiment, Gandhi came to confront and finally face down his 'fear and trembling' – a condition that runs like a *leitmotif* through the entire text. In so much of *An Autobiography*, Gandhi's sense of physical fear is palpable: at the prospect of speaking – at school, on board ship, before the courts of law, even when, already a political personage, he was called to